

Esophagectomy Feeding Tubes

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Cancers in the esophagus can cause difficulty with eating, which can limit your body's ability to get the nutrition you need in order to keep your body healthy during cancer treatment.

In many cases, an enteral feeding tube can help make sure your body can get the nutrients it needs.

A feeding tube can be used to administer

Formula

Water

and Medicines

Importantly, a feeding tube will not interfere with your ability to take food, medicines, and water by mouth.

Patients with esophageal cancer not infrequently have an obstruction of the esophagus and

A gastrostomy tube is placed into the stomach, so it is ideal for patients that have tumor in the esophagus or the top of the stomach. A gastrostomy tube is also ideal for patients with difficulty swallowing due to neurological diseases such as ALS.

There are several methods for tube placement for gastrostomy tubes:

- Under fluoroscopy by a radiologist. In this technique, a temporary tube is passed through the nose into the esophagus and then the stomach. Air is then injected through the tube in order to fill the stomach. X-rays are then taken to see the air in the stomach. The skin is cleansed and local anesthetic injected into the skin of the abdominal wall. A needle is passed into the stomach, and a tube is then placed through this area.

The advantages of the fluoroscopic technique is that it does not require surgery. This technique does require that the stomach lie in the correct position just underneath the skin. A CT scan is commonly performed prior to a fluoroscopic gastrostomy tube to confirm the position of the stomach.

An alternative is a percutaneous endoscopic gastrostomy technique, or PEG.

In this technique, an endoscope is passed through the mouth into the stomach. A needle is then passed through the skin into the stomach, and a tube brought into place.

For patients with cancer of the esophagus or gastroesophageal junction who may eventually need surgery, things get a bit complicated.

In most cases, when surgery is performed to remove a cancer of the esophagus or gastroesophageal junction, a new esophagus is fashioned from the stomach. A gastrostomy tube is *also* placed into the stomach. There is a small but real risk that a gastrostomy tube might cause damage to the stomach that would make it more difficult to construct a new esophagus from the stomach.

for patients that may require surgery in the future, there are two options:

- 1) The first is a jejunostomy tube, which is the safest option, because the tube is placed into the jejunum, the first portion of the small intestine, leaving the stomach undisturbed. The disadvantage of a jejunostomy is that the feedings are less convenient, because they need to be administered by slow infusion with a pump over 12-16 hours.
- 2) The second option is to place a gastrostomy tube with laparoscopy. This is a surgical procedure which allows the gastrostomy tube to be placed precisely in the stomach in such a way that the stomach can still be used to make a new esophagus in the future.

Your surgeon will make a recommendation for the best approach for a feeding tube in your situation.